Village Mayor Conversation — Talking Points

Meeting with Mitsue Village Mayor (御杖村長)

For Rob's preparation — confidential

Important Context for This Meeting

This is **not a first introduction** of either Rob or the project. You are building on:

- An informal meeting with the **Vice Mayor (副村長)** approximately 6 months ago, in which you presented a draft concept of the small-scale AI data center using the closed Mitsue Elementary School. Biomass, biogas, and forestry components were **not** mentioned at that meeting.
- An informal meeting with the **local forestry group** approximately 4 months ago, exploring how they work and whether collaboration is possible.

This changes the meeting in three meaningful ways:

1. **The mayor likely already knows about the AI data center idea** — the vice mayor will almost certainly have briefed him. Don't pretend it's new.
2. **You are now broadening the picture** — adding the biomass/biogas energy and forestry components transforms a single-building proposal into an integrated rural sustainability project. This is the most important shift to communicate.
3. **You have already shown respect** for proper village process by approaching the vice mayor first and the forestry group separately. That groundwork is in your favor — let it work for you.

Strategic Goal of This Meeting

The goal is to:

1. **Acknowledge and build on** the previous conversation with the vice mayor
2. **Reveal the broader integrated picture** — energy, forestry, and the data center as one project
3. **Listen carefully** to the mayor's reaction now that the picture is fuller
4. **Gauge his appetite** for the village taking a more active role
5. **Seek his guidance** on next steps

The tone should still be consultative, not promotional, but you can be more substantive than in a true first meeting. Aim for **roughly 50/50 listening and talking** — more talking than a cold introduction would warrant, but still listening more than presenting.

Before the Meeting

- **Request through the vice mayor's office if possible** — this acknowledges the proper chain and signals respect to both

- **Bring a small, thoughtful gift** (お土産)
- **Wear formal attire** — suit and tie
- **Bring Yuka or your Japanese co-founder if available** — strongly recommended given the broader scope of the discussion
- **Bring one simple visual** — a single sheet showing the three integrated elements (forest, energy, school). NOT a full proposal, but a one-page concept that helps explain the broadening picture. Something visual is helpful when you're describing how three things connect.
- **Take notes after the meeting, not during**

Opening (First 5 Minutes)

Suggested Opening

After the standard greetings and exchange of cards:

> "村長、お忙しい中、お時間をいただきまして誠にありがとうございます。半年ほど前に副村長にお話を伺っていた件に関連して、その後の進展を村長にもご報告し、ご相談したく、本日参りました。"
>
> *("Mayor, thank you very much for your time. Regarding the matter I discussed with the Vice Mayor about six months ago, I have come today to report on subsequent developments and to seek your guidance.")*

Acknowledge the Vice Mayor

Make clear you understand the proper protocol and that the vice mayor has been your point of contact:

> "副村長には、御杖小学校の活用について、ささやかな構想をお話しさせていただきました。その後、私自身もう少し考えを深めまして、最初にお話しした内容よりも広がりのある構想になってまいりましたので、村長にも直接ご相談したく存じた次第です。"
>
> *("With the Vice Mayor, I shared a modest concept regarding the use of Mitsue Elementary School. Since then, I have developed my thinking further, and the concept has broadened beyond what I first discussed. I therefore wished to consult with you directly, Mayor.")*

This phrasing accomplishes several things at once: it signals respect for protocol, it admits the picture has changed, and it positions the broader plan as a natural development rather than a sudden pivot.

Listen Phase (Next 10–15 Minutes)

Even though you have history here, still begin with listening. The mayor's perspective on what's happened in the village in the months since your last contact is valuable.

Opening Questions

1. **"副村長から、当時の構想について何かお話を伺っていらっしゃいますでしょうか?"** *("Has the Vice Mayor mentioned anything to you about that earlier concept?")*

   This lets him reveal what he already knows without you guessing.

2. **"この半年の間に、村として閉校舎の活用について何か動きはございましたでしょうか?"** *("Has there been any movement at the village level regarding use of the closed school in the past six months?")*

   Important — there may be other proposals in play, or a new direction you don't know about.

3. **"杉の人工林や森林管理について、最近何か検討事項はございますか?"** *("Are there any recent discussions about cedar plantations or forest management?")*

   Tests whether your forestry group conversations have circulated, and whether the village has its own forestry initiatives in motion.

What to Listen For

- **What the vice mayor relayed (or didn't)** — gives you a sense of how the earlier meeting was received
- **Any other proposals for the school** — competing ideas you need to know about
- **Existing forestry plans** — your project must align with, not compete against, village forestry direction
- **The mayor's tone** — engaged? cautious? deferring? Each tells you something

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The Bridge — Revealing the Broader Picture (10–15 Minutes)

This is the heart of the meeting. You are now connecting the AI data center concept (which he likely already knows) with the forestry and energy components (which he likely doesn't).

Suggested Framing

> "副村長にお話しした際は、閉校舎の活用という一点に絞った構想でした。ですが、その後、地元の林業の方々ともお話をする機会がございまして、考え方が大きく変わってまいりました。"
>
> *("When I spoke with the Vice Mayor, the concept was focused only on the use of the closed school. However, since then, I have had the opportunity to speak with the local forestry group, and my thinking has changed significantly.")*

Introduce the Three Connected Elements

Now you can be more substantive. Use your one-page visual if helpful.

> "現在は、3つの要素がつながった、より統合的な構想として考えております。"
>
> *("I am now thinking of it as a more integrated concept, in which three elements are connected.")*

> "1つ目は、杉の人工林を、長い時間をかけて在来種に戻していくこと。これは林業の方々ともお話ししたところ、関心を持っていただける可能性があると感じております。"
>
> *(First, gradually returning sugi plantations to native species over a long period. From my conversation with the forestry group, I sensed there may be openness to this.)*

> "2つ目は、伐採される杉を、地域のクリーンエネルギーとして活用すること。最初は小型バイオマスボイラーによる熱供給から始め、温室や村の施設の暖房・給湯にお使いいただく考えでございます。発電は、需要と採算性が整いました段階で、後の段階として検討してまいります。"

> *(Second, using the harvested cedar as local clean energy. We would begin with a small biomass boiler providing heat for greenhouses and village facilities — at this scale, heat is more efficient and useful than electricity. Electrical generation would come as a later stage when demand and economics support it.)*

This framing matters: the mayor — like most listeners — may otherwise picture a "biomass power plant", which is a much larger and more capital-intensive project than what is intended. Setting the thermal-first scale early prevents that mental image taking hold.

> "3つ目は、そのエネルギーを使って、副村長にお話しした閉校舎の活用構想を支える、というつながりでございます。"
>
> *(Third, using that energy to support the school-use concept I shared with the Vice Mayor — these elements connecting together.)*

Acknowledge the Magnitude of the Shift

Be honest that this is a meaningful expansion of what was previously discussed:

> "副村長にお話しした時よりも、はるかに大きな構想となっております。それゆえに、村長のお考えを直接伺いたく、お時間を頂戴した次第です。"
>
> *("This is a much larger concept than what I discussed with the Vice Mayor. For that reason, I wished to hear your thoughts directly, Mayor, which is why I have come today.")*

Frame the Long Horizon

This is also the right moment to introduce the 25-year scale, because it changes the nature of the ask:

> "また、時間軸につきましても、25年という長期的な取り組みとして考えております。1年や2年で何かを完成させるという話ではなく、世代を超えて村に貢献できる形を、ゆっくりと築いていきたいと考えております。"
>
> *("Regarding the timeline as well, I am thinking of this as a 25-year long-term initiative. This is not about completing something in one or two years, but about slowly building a form that can contribute to the village across generations.")*

The 25-year framing is itself reassuring to a rural mayor — it signals you are not trying to extract value quickly, but to commit for the long term.

Soft Ask (Last 10 Minutes)

Because of the prior groundwork, your ask can be slightly more concrete than in a true first meeting.

What You Are Asking For

1. **The mayor's own reaction** — does the broadened picture make sense to him?
2. **Guidance on whom to consult next** — which 自治会 leaders, council members, prefectural contacts
3. **An indication** of whether the village would be open to formal collaboration in due course (NOT a commitment, just openness)

4. **Whether he prefers** further communication to go through the vice mayor or directly to him

Suggested Phrasing

> "村長から見て、このような統合的な方向性に何かご懸念がございましたら、率直にお聞かせいただきたく存じます。また、もしお進めしてよろしいようでしたら、次にどなたにご相談すべきか、ご助言いただければ幸いです。"
>
> *("If, from the Mayor's view, there are any concerns about this integrated direction, I would appreciate your candid opinion. If it would be acceptable to proceed, I would be grateful for guidance on whom to consult next.")*

> "また、今後のご相談につきましては、引き続き副村長を通じてさせていただくのか、村長に直接ご連絡差し上げるのが適切か、ご教示いただけますと幸いです。"
>
> *("Regarding future discussions, I would also welcome your guidance on whether I should continue through the Vice Mayor, or whether direct contact with you, Mayor, would be appropriate.")*

This last question is important — it explicitly respects the chain of command and lets him define how the relationship should work going forward.

Possible Mayor Reactions and Responses

Reaction A: "Yes, the Vice Mayor mentioned this. Interesting that it has grown."

Your response: Express gratitude, acknowledge the broadening:

> "おっしゃる通り、当初よりはるかに広がっております。だからこそ、慎重にご相談したいと考えております."

Reaction B: "I had not heard about this from the Vice Mayor."

Your response: Don't appear surprised or critical. Simply explain:

> "副村長にはささやかな構想としてご相談しただけですので、村長にまでお伝えいただくほどの段階ではなかったかと思います."

This protects the vice mayor and avoids any awkwardness.

Reaction C: "The forestry group has already mentioned your visit to me."

Your response: Good — your respect for protocol has been noticed. Acknowledge it:

> "そうでしたか。皆様にお話を伺いながら、勉強させていただいている段階でございます."

Reaction D: "This is much bigger than I expected. We need to think carefully."

Your response: This is a reasonable and welcome reaction. Reinforce patience:

> "おっしゃる通りでございます。私どもも、慎重に時間をかけて進めるべき構想だと考えております. 何年もかけて、段階的に進めていきたいと存じます."

Reaction E: "There may be conflicts with [other plan / interests]."

Your response: Listen carefully. Don't argue. Ask:

> "ご懸念の点を、もう少し具体的にお聞かせいただけますでしょうか? それを踏まえて、構想を見直したいと存じます."

This is critical information you can only get by listening.

Reaction F: "We need to involve [other person/body] now that this is bigger."

Your response: Welcome this. The mayor pointing you to additional stakeholders is a positive signal — he's helping you navigate the village.

> "ご教示いただきありがとうございます。村長のご助言に従って、適切な順序でご相談を進めてまいります."

If the Mayor Asks Substantive Questions

The mayor may probe the practical mechanics. Full bilingual answers live in `mitsue_qa_briefing.md`. Compressed answers for live use:

"How big is the plant? Can village cedar power the village?"

> "実証段階の規模でございまして、村全体の電力をバイオマスで賄うことは目的としておりません。バイオマス、既存の太陽光、電力会社の組み合わせを想定しております。正確な数値は第2段階のフィージビリティスタディで算出いたします."
>
> *(Pilot scale, not utility scale. Not aiming to power the entire village from biomass alone. Realistic mix is biomass + existing solar + grid. Firm figures from Phase 2 feasibility.)*

"What is the heat used for?"

> "温室、村の施設、給湯、木材乾燥、冬季の融雪など、多様に活用できます。小規模では、熱は電気よりも価値が高うございまして、最初は熱供給から始めるのが最も効率的でございます."
>
> *(Greenhouses, village facilities, hot water, lumber drying, winter snow-melt. At small scale, heat is more valuable than electricity — thermal-first is the most efficient pilot path.)*

"Why is a data center necessary?"

> "データセンターは24時間稼働するため、バイオマスの経済性を成り立たせる安定した需要先となります。これがないと、日本の小規模バイオマスは経済的に成立しないのが通例でございまして、データセンターはエネルギー事業を可能にする鍵でございます."
>
> *(The data center provides 24/7 baseload demand that makes biomass economically viable. Without an anchor offtaker, small biomass projects in Japan typically fail their financials. The data center is what enables the energy project.)*

"We have many solar panels already. Why biomass?"

> "太陽光とバイオマスは競合ではなく補完の関係でございます。太陽光は日中、バイオマスは夜間と冬。さらにバイオマスは熱を生み出し、村の杉という現在の負債を資源に変えるという、太陽光単独では解決できない課題に応えるものでございます."
>
> *(Solar and biomass are complementary, not competitive. Solar by day; biomass at night and in winter. Biomass also produces heat, and converts the cedar-management problem from liability to feedstock — solar alone cannot solve that.)*

"Will benefits really take 25 years?"

> "25年は森林再生の生態的な期間でございます。村への具体的な恩恵はもっと早く現れます。1年目で閉校舎の再活用とメディア発信、2年目で山林所有者への伐採収入、3〜4年目で熱供給とEV充電、4〜5年目でデータセンターの地域雇用が始まります."
>
> *(The 25-year horizon applies to forest restoration ecology. Concrete village benefits arrive much earlier — school reactivation and media in Year 1, landowner income in Year 2, heat and EV charging in Year 3–4, data center jobs in Year 4–5.)*

"Biomass is expensive. How will the costs be managed?"

> "決定的な単一の解決策ではなく、複数の対策の積み重ねでございます: 熱供給からの開始、林野庁・経産省・FIT/FIP・J-クレジット・NEDOなどの補助制度の重ね合わせ、熱の商品化、製材との組み合わせ、そして数値が見合わなければ無理に進めない原則でございます."
>
> *(Not a single fix but a stack: start thermal (one-third the cost of CHP), stack subsidies that biomass uniquely qualifies for, sell heat as a product, pair with timber, and hold rather than force the project if the numbers don't work.)*

If the mayor asks something not on this list, it is better to say *"村長、その点は専門家とともに改めて整理してご報告させていただきとう存じます"* (*"Mayor, allow me to come back to you on that point with our specialists"*) than to improvise. Promising to follow up is more credible than guessing.

After the Meeting

- **Send a thank-you note within 48 hours** — handwritten if possible, formal Japanese
- **Send a courtesy note to the vice mayor** as well, briefly mentioning that you met with the mayor and acknowledging the vice mayor's earlier helpfulness. This is essential — never let the vice mayor feel bypassed.
- **Wait for the mayor's guidance** before contacting any new figures he mentioned
- **Document everything** in private notes
- **Update the forestry group**, briefly, that you have spoken with the mayor about the broader integrated concept. They should not hear it from someone else.

Key Differences From a Cold First Meeting

Because you have history with the vice mayor and the forestry group, this meeting is different in several ways:

- **You can be more substantive** — the mayor expects you to have developed thinking, not just an idea
- **You must acknowledge the prior contacts** — pretending this is fresh would seem dishonest
- **The "broadening" message is the central insight** — connecting school + forestry + energy is the new information
- **Your soft ask can be more concrete** — including a question about ongoing communication channels
- **The protocol of having approached the vice mayor first works in your favor** — let him notice that, but don't oversell it

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Mental Reminders

- **You are continuing a conversation, not starting one.** Behave accordingly.
- **The vice mayor is an ally**, not a stepping stone — keep that relationship strong throughout
- **The forestry group is also an ally** — they are part of your credibility now
- **Patience signals respect.** Even with prior groundwork, do not push for fast decisions.
- **You will be remembered for how you behaved**, not what you proposed.

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